

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

to be more mature; it needs to reach to the grassroots. Our vote share increased from seven to 14 per cent. In future, we will expand more rapidly.

Q. Looking at 2024, what sort of lessons are you taking home from the polls in nine states in 2023? Are there talks on with erstwhile allies like the Akali Dal and TDP for seat-sharing arrangements?

While we take every election seriously, the situation in every state differs. You have to be flexible and pragmatic; the response to a situation should be swift. Every poll factor, right from the leadership of PM Modi, is in our favour for 2024. It depends upon us to use it to the full. Assembly and Lok Sabha polls are different. We are selecting candidates, and also retaining what we have and all this is going on since a year back. We have expanded our base, earmarked 150 LS seats where we have not won and on which we are concentrating. In some states, we do face a leadership question; but when it comes to Lok Sabha polls, PM Modi is there. As far as the TDP or Akali Dal is concerned, we have had no talk with them on this.

Q. It seems the INDIA formation is planning for regional leaders to fight in their own turfs and they hope to have seat-sharing arrangements so that the strongest candidates get tickets. Do you see the new alliance as a challenge to the BJP?

Tell me, what will Mamata get in UP for Akhilesh in terms of votes? What will Akhilesh fetch in Bengal, or Sharad Pawar in Chhattisgarh? What has Mamata gained in Goa, or (Arvind) Kejriwal in Himachal? They don't have influence areas. There is no transfer of votes in the INDIA bloc. They have alliances, but they are unlikely to translate into votes.

> "WHAT HAS MAMATA GAINED IN GOA OR KEJRIWAL IN HIMACHAL? THE INDIA BLOC PARTIES DON'T HAVE AREAS OF INFLUENCE. THERE IS NO TRANSFER OF VOTES FOR THEM"

Q. Opposition parties say that India's post-pandemic economy growth is K-shaped, with the rich getting richer and the poor getting worse. What are your views on this?

This is a politically motivated narrative. Modi*ji* is taking care from the micro economy to macro economy. Why, 13.5 crore people have come up from below the poverty line. Is that not important economically? Secondly, consumption has expanded. Earlier, the common man was stuck in concerns over *roti-kapda-makaan* (food, clothing, housing) and medicine. But in PM Modi's regime, each of these concerns has been taken care of through schemes like Ayushman Bharat, Pradhan Mantri Anna Yojana, Awas Yojana, subsidised gas etc. The common man has spare cash now. So, the 'rich is becoming richer' is a false statement. The economy is being given a boost. Our benefits are well-directed, well-targeted and they empower people.

Q. The BJP always sets the theme. In 2014, we saw PM Modi as a symbol of hope; in 2019, he was as saviour of national security and a doer. What is is BJP's theme for the 2024 election?

The country needs stability. Stability lies in Modi and BJP. He has delivered on all fronts. So, people want to go forward. The agenda is now Viksit Bharat at 2047. The common man believes that India will become the third largest economy in PM Modi's third term. ■